

Chapter 101-5

Both of them ate little for dinner. Sitting at the same dining table, neither spoke, quietly finishing their meal. Liang Shi went to clean up while Xu Qingzhu went to the bathroom to shower.

When she came out, she found Liang Shi sitting on the sofa with several sheets of paper spread out in front of her. The papers were covered with densely packed dots—someone who didn't know better would have thought it was someone's random doodles.

Liang Shi was using a translation app to re-translate, with a notebook and pen on her lap, neatly copying down the contents.

Xu Qingzhu asked, "Is this the original?"

"No." Liang Shi said, "This paper was torn from Rainbow's kindergarten lesson plan book. It should have been transcribed by Gu Xingyue."

What did Gu Xingyue want by giving her these?

A cry for help?

Liang Shi had been thinking about this question.

She didn't know what had happened to Gu Xingyue right now—whether she had been placed under strict surveillance by Yang Jiani again because of contacting her, or because her relationship with Cheng Ran had been exposed.

But it was also strange. Yang Jiani kept such strict watch over her that logically she should have imprisoned her at home, so why would she still let her go work at the kindergarten?

And back when Gu Xingyue took the college entrance exam, she had scored over six hundred points—clearly good enough to study in the capital city. Yet she stayed in Haizhou City to study early childhood education, wasting over a hundred points for nothing.

She had discussed this question with Xu Qingzhu before. They both leaned toward the idea that Gu Xingyue had made some kind of agreement with Yang Jiani while still in school and had been fighting for her own rights all along.

Although Gu Xingyue also seemed very gentle, as soft as water when dealing with children, she was different from Qi Jiao.

Qi Jiao had faced her own biological mother, oppression from childhood to adulthood. But Gu Xingyue had come into the picture later. To her, Yang Jiani was simply a crazy woman, and she was just trying to survive under a crazy woman's control.

So in a sense, Gu Xingyue would be braver than Qi Jiao, more intimidating to Yang Jiani and harder for her to control.

Liang Shi worked on these things until very late. Xu Qingzhu sat beside her with her laptop, leaning against the sofa and handling documents.

It wasn't until after ten o'clock at night that Liang Shi stretched and put everything away, then asked Xu Qingzhu, "Is Sheng Yu okay?"

"Yes." Xu Qingzhu said, "She didn't hit anything vital."

"That's good then." Liang Shi breathed a sigh of relief. Before she could say anything else, she yawned, her eyelids drooping, barely able to stay open.

Xu Qingzhu closed her laptop and comforted her. "Don't think so much. Go to sleep early. Wait until Monday to go check at the kindergarten entrance, or wait for Gu Xingyue to contact us. If you really can't wait, you can ask Sister-in-law to help. There's always a way."

"Mm-hmm." Liang Shi responded. She curled up on the sofa, her voice muffled. "I just feel sorry toward Gu Zhaoyuan."

She had already made arrangements with Gu Zhaoyuan. He had come to the city all excited, but ended up not seeing Gu Xingyue.

It felt like she had broken a promise.

Xu Qingzhu said helplessly, "Teacher Liang, can you please stop blaming yourself for everything? This was an accident to begin with. Why do you have to feel guilty even about something like this?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi sheepishly touched her nose. "Got it."

She looked like someone who had been scolded and was now dutifully heeding the lesson.

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

She thought her tone had been quite gentle, and she had spoken with the intention of comforting Liang Shi. Yet somehow Liang Shi seemed a bit aggrieved?

She wasn't sure if it was just her imagination.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu suddenly sat down beside her, very close. "Liang Shi, are you in a bad mood today?"

Liang Shi nodded, then shook her head. "It was okay at first, but after seeing Qi Jiao's diary, I couldn't suppress the sadness."

That kind of emotion—the more you deliberately try to suppress it, the more it rises.

You try to ignore it, only to find it's like a thorn that keeps pricking you, making it impossible to ignore.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She fell silent, because she realized she wasn't good at comforting people and didn't know where to start.

Compared to comforting, Xu Qingzhu was better at finding problems and solving them.

"Alright." Liang Shi stood up, stretched, and pretended to be nonchalant. "Let's sleep early. Everything will be fine when we wake up tomorrow. Oh right, Teacher Xu, the escape room we couldn't go to today—can we arrange it for tomorrow?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Okay."

Then she also stood up and walked toward the master bedroom, preoccupied with thoughts. When she reached the doorway, she suddenly turned around, only to meet the gaze of Liang Shi, who had also suddenly turned around at the doorway of the second bedroom.

Liang Shi's expression showed she wanted to say something but hesitated. Xu Qingzhu also paused.

After a moment, Liang Shi asked in a muffled voice, "Xu Qingzhu, tonight... can I sleep with you?"

Her mission was about to fail. Even though this question was abrupt and shameless, she had no choice but to ask it thick-skinned.

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The question was very abrupt.

But Xu Qingzhu agreed.

Liang Shi carried her own blanket to Xu Qingzhu's room, then went to the bathroom to wash up. When she returned to the room after washing up, Xu Qingzhu was leaning against the headboard reading a book—a collection of English poetry with a blue cover in her hands.

Her fine, soft hair hung down, making her look peaceful and beautiful. Only in the instant she raised her eyes could one feel the coolness in her gaze.

But it was only for an instant. When she saw it was Liang Shi, her eyes curved slightly, everything natural and unforced.

This scene was like returning to when Liang Shi had just transmigrated. They had shared a room, and often when Liang Shi came out after showering, she would see Xu Qingzhu reading. Back then, her gaze was even more piercing than now, carrying a hidden hostility and disgust.

Although they shared the same bed, it was like being separated by the Milky Way—neither would touch the other throughout the entire night.

Back then, Xu Qingzhu slept very lightly, waking up at almost any sound, like a startled bird. But now she could calmly face Liang Shi, who was about to lie in the same bed with her.

She even felt a faint sense of anticipation.

Liang Shi's hair wasn't dry yet. Xu Qingzhu put down her book and called to her, "Bring the hair dryer over. I'll blow-dry it for you."

Liang Shi hesitated for a moment but listened to her. To make it more convenient for her, Liang Shi sat there lazily, her back hunched quite a bit. Xu Qingzhu sat on the bed and earnestly blow-dried her hair, her slender pale fingers threading through the brown strands. Liang Shi lowered her head and thought: How should I spend this long night?

There was still a key point to the system's mission: coax Xu Qingzhu to sleep by singing or telling a story.

Xu Qingzhu dried Liang Shi's hair until it was about seventy to eighty percent dry, then turned off the hair dryer. It suddenly became much quieter.

Xu Qingzhu lay back under the covers. Liang Shi went to put the hair dryer back in its place, then suddenly turned around and casually touched Xu Qingzhu's hair.

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly. "It's already dry."

Liang Shi unconsciously smiled along with her. "It is dry."

When she returned from the bathroom again, the curtains in the room had been drawn tight, the main light had been turned off, leaving only the two dim lamps at the bedside.

Xu Qingzhu lay languidly on the bed, eyes half-closed, wearing a white spaghetti-strap nightgown. Her arms and upper body were exposed outside the covers, her forearms fair and slender. One could vaguely see her impressive curves.

Liang Shi: "....."

She walked over and pulled Xu Qingzhu's blanket up higher. Xu Qingzhu suddenly opened her eyes, her voice carrying a husky drowsiness. "Let's sleep."

Liang Shi responded with an "mm," then went around to the other side and carefully lay down, reaching out to turn off the lamp on her side.

Xu Qingzhu turned over, facing her. The soft light illuminated her entire face beautifully. She draped her arm over Liang Shi's body and said in a low voice, "Teacher Liang, sing a song."

Liang Shi: "?"